parlance refers to written communication. It may be either received or sent out. A mail received is known as inward mail and a communication sent out is called as outward mail. As stated already, every business organization receives as well as sends a large number of mail every day.

8.5.2. Definitions:

George R. Terry rightly remarked that "it is doubtful that a modern office could exist without mail". The reason is obvious that every business house has to maintain close contact with the outside world. It should correspond to its customers, its own branches, departments, and various other institutions, government etc. when the business firm grows; the volume of transactions will also grow.

8.5.3. Procedure for Mail Handling:



Fig. 8.2. Incoming Mail Handling Procedure

1. **Receiving the Mail:** Generally mails are received once or twice a day as delivered by the postman, when the volume of correspondence is large, a post box or post bag is hired in the post office, and an office peon is sent to collect the mail from the post office. Sometimes letters are received through the messengers of the offices. In the emerging scenario private courier services renders speedy service to the office.

2. **Sorting the Mail:** After the mail has been received in the mailing department, it should be sorted out before it is opened. It is easier to sort out sealed envelopes than different sized pieces of paper. Private letters of the employees may be sorted out at first than comparing to the business letters.

Business Letters should be sorted out into three groups:

a) Registered and unregistered letters or mail;

b) Sealed and unsealed envelopes; and

c) Confidential and urgent letters, private or personal, secret, and other official letters.

Sorting of letters means grouping of letters on definite order. Sorted mail makes the delivery of letters convenient and quick.

3. **Opening the Mail:** Letters may be opened by hand or by letter opening machines. A paper knife is mostly used in offices to split open envelopes etc. If the number of letters is very large, a letter opening machine may be used with advantage. In small organisation letters are opened by the officer or head clerk. The following guidelines may be followed for opening the mail.

a) The sorting and opening of the mail should start atleast half an hour to one

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